the implacable force of the Mughal army. Chand Sultan understood the limits of resistance in the face of formidable odds and, pragmatic, sent letters to Abu'l Fazl, promising help if Ahang Khan were defeated. She asked for Bir to be made her fief following which she would hand over the keys to the city and 'go to court whenever it was wished, and would send Bahadur to wait upon His Majesty'. In the midst of these negotiations, an order arrived from the approaching imperial army that Abu'l Fazl was to wait for Daniyal to arrive with his forces. With the stampeding forces of the Mughal army at her door, Chand Sultan finally decided to make overtures to the Mughals. But this was just the opportunity her enemies were waiting for. Officers of rival factions ran into the streets of Ahmadnagar, screaming that the queen had betrayed them to the Mughals, and collected an armed mob. Storming Chand Sultan's private residence the mob cut her to pieces with their swords and knives.

The Mughal army led by Daniyal, and accompanied by Abu'l Fazl, attacked Ahmadnagar Fort with concentrated effort. After a siege of four months, the moat was filled up and mines detonated at the walls which caused huge cracks in the outer defences. The soldiers stormed the breaches and 1,500 of the garrison of Ahmadnagar were put to the sword. A great deal of treasure was captured, 'valuable jewels, embroidered articles, a noble library and many other things, and 25 elephants were obtained'. Young Bahadur, the Nizam Shah, was captured and sent to Akbar, and imprisoned for the rest of his life in Gwalior Fort.

After Ahmadnagar fell, resistance spread to the countryside where two men rallied the majority of the leaderless soldiers to their standard. Raju Deccani had once been in the service of a nobleman of Ahmadnagar while the other leader was Malik Ambar. While professing allegiance to the Nizam Shahis, these two men, sworn enemies, would nonetheless harbour sprawling ambitions of their own. Malik Ambar, notwithstanding his genteel title, had had an obscure birth but his career had displayed a remarkable trajectory. Born Shambu, or Chapu, in Ethiopia around 1550, he was sold into slavery by his impoverished parents. Shambu's precocious intelligence was noticed and rewarded by his Baghdadi owners. He was converted to Islam, taught Arabic, trained in administration, and given the name Ambar, meaning 'precious jewel'. Ambar travelled with his owner to the Deccan, probably on business, and was sold to a Deccani called Malik Dabir. Fortuitously for Ambar, Malik Dabir was an Ethiopian, and peshwa